those certified by the Institut de Soudure (French Welding Institute) to work on the welding floor. I vouched for our man's skills, but the French would have none of it. A rule, after all, was a rule. So, our star welder was given strips of aluminium to play with, while the certified welders worked on the dome and other critical structures of the rocket engine.

How does one get a certificate from Institut de Soudure, I inquired with some SEP heads. They just smiled. It was indeed very tough to pass the test. Many of the master welders at SEP had cleared the test after a minimum of three attempts. SEP officials said it would be a waste of time and money—yes, taking the test cost a bomb—for Raj to attempt it.

Having seen the SEP welders at work, I knew Raj could match them, if not outclass them. When I insisted, SEP was kind enough to give me a loan to apply for Raj's certification. Raj took the welding test and passed it in the first attempt. SEP engineers were so much in awe that they got the administration to waive off the loan they gave for Raj's test fees. A star was reborn in Vernon.

Raj was inducted into the core team of welders working on the injector dome. The professionals that they were, the French welders and their supervisors held back no praise that our man deserved. A few weeks later, as I was noting how the experience he would gain here in Vernon would be significant for us when we got back home to put together the Vikas engine, Raj came to me with some 'confidential' news. SEP had offered him a job with ten times the salary he was drawing at ISRO.

Raj had told his prospective poachers that he would do nothing without my permission. I told him to the offer, and he did it without any questions. Later, visiting his house on the outskirts of Nagercoil after his death, I felt guilty for not allowing him to go. He had left behind his family in a modest house he had built with a loan, which was yet to be repaid. Raj could have built ten palatial houses by now, I thought, had I allowed him to take up the French offer.

He welded some of the crucial parts of the first few Vikas engines and PSLV rockets. He was also instrumental in training welders of Godrej and MTAR Technologies, which now mass produce Vikas engines for ISRO.